Topic 1 Position Paper

Committee: United Nations Office on Outer Space Affairs (UNOOSA)

Agenda: The Question of Preventing Anti-Satellite Weapon Tests by Major Powers

Delegation: Israel

Name: Jules Kitto-Astrop

Topic Background

Outer space remains one of the largest unknown variables in today's world posing several multifaceted questions relating to the past, current, and future use of space. One of the greatest challenges faced by individuals involved in space exploration is the question of anti-satellite weapon testing, where the regulatory frameworks must consider both inter-planetary safety and future sustainability of space objects while also ensuring a level of national sovereignty is protected. The greatest threats to outer space safety are the highly developed programs belonging to nations such as the United States, Russian Federation, Republic of China, and India. The aforementioned nations are major contributors to international space technology and testing but are also the main sources of man-made space debris. As of 2022, the total mass of space debris in Earth's orbit is estimated to be 8 million kilograms (9 tonnes), almost equivalent to the Eiffel Tower. Preventing and removing space debris remains one of the largest priorities of COPUOS and UNOOSA, without immediate intervention, the existence of space debris in orbits can result in Kessler Syndrome – a theoretical chain reaction caused by the collisions of space debris, eventually rendering orbits (especially low earth orbits, where objects travel at extreme velocities) unusable for centuries.

Past International Actions

Historical tests provide an urgent push to address issues regarding space safety and international peacekeeping. Notably, the 2021 PL-19 Nudol Mission, carried out by Russia contributed around 1500 trackable pieces of debris after successfully destroying a prior Russian satellite which became inactive in 1984. ASAT testing itself remains highly controversial with certain member states calling for the eradication of weapons in space. Despite the serious implications of space debris, members continue to advocate for the testing of weapons in space for numerous reasons including; national security, debris removal, and the demonstration of military power. Previously, COPUOS has guided the implementation of the current regulatory standards; UN Resolution 77/41 (2022) which details the ideal obligations of member states in relation to the use of outer space. According to Ching Wei Sooi, the degree of effectiveness of Resolution 77/41 is moderate with several relevant benefits and drawbacks. The resolution contributed to the development of "norms" prohibiting destructive ASAT testing – in light of Russia's 2021 Nudol test, these "norms" provided a crucial foundation for further

space activity regulation aiming to achieve responsible international space governance. Alongside the benefits of the resolution, drawbacks remain detrimental to progress. Despite the large number of resolution supporters, three out of four of the “major powers” were opposed or abstained from voting indicating future roadblocks in the development of international regulations. Furthermore, the resolution itself remains partially effective with the primary issue being the nature of the resolution, as a UNGA resolution, policies are not legally binding but instead reliant on goodwill and integrity of nations to uphold the frameworks. UNOOSA stands firm in the belief that outer space should remain usable for both federal and commercial use, requiring peaceful exploration and implementation of space technology to maintain a safe and equitable space environment. As described in the Outer Space Treaty of 1967,

Country Policy

Israel stands

Solutions

Israel advocates for

Bibliography

Topic 2 Position Paper

Committee: United Nations Office on Outer Space Affairs (UNOOSA)

Agenda: The Question of Regulating Commercial Lunar and Asteroid Mining Missions

Delegation: Israel

Name: Jules Kitto-Astrop

Topic Background

The cultivation of natural resources has been a long lasting priority for many nations, the current means of extracting and utilizing natural resources remain harmful in the long-run and call for the implementation of stricter regulations that protect the environment. In the context of space exploration, the extraction of natural resources from celestial bodies is a topic of debate with many confounding variables.

Past International Actions

Country Policy

Solutions

Bibliography